

TOP 25

California DMV

FREE STUDY GUIDE · 2026 EDITION

5 Sections
Covered

25 Key
Questions

Full Answer
Explanations

Covers 2026 California laws: AB 390 · AB 366 · AB 1087

Safe Drive Academy · California DMV Practice Test 2026 · Available on Amazon

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

These 25 questions are the ones that trip up most California DMV first-timers. Each comes directly from the *California DMV Practice Test 2026* book. Answer every question, then check the answer box — and always read the explanation, even when you get it right.

★ **Watch for NEVER, ALWAYS, EXCEPT**

These words flip the correct answer. Slow down when you see them.

★ **Pick the SAFER answer**

When two options seem right, choose the more cautious one.

★ **The full book has 500+ questions**

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CHAPT
ER 1

California State-Specific Laws (2026)

Q1 California's 'Hands-Free' cell phone law requires:

- A No phone use at all while driving
- B A mounted, hands-free device — holding the phone in any way is illegal
- C Hands-free allowed only above 25 mph

✓ **Correct Answer: B) A mounted, hands-free device — holding the phone in any way is illegal**

California requires that any phone use while driving use a hands-free device that is mounted on the windshield, dashboard, or center console. Holding the phone — even for GPS — is illegal. Fine: \$162+ first offense.

Q2 In California, the Move Over law (AB 390, effective January 1, 2026) now applies to:

- A Police and fire vehicles only
- B Emergency vehicles, tow trucks, and CalTrans vehicles
- C Any stationary vehicle displaying hazard lights or warning devices

✓ **Correct Answer: C) Any stationary vehicle displaying hazard lights or warning devices**

California's expanded Move Over law (effective 2026) requires drivers to move over or slow down for ANY stationary vehicle on the road displaying hazard lights, cones, or flares — not just emergency vehicles.

Q3 Lane splitting by motorcyclists in California is:

- A Illegal
- B Legal — California is the first U.S. state to formally legalize it
- C Legal only on highways

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Legal — California is the first U.S. state to formally legalize it**

California is the only U.S. state where lane splitting (riding between lanes of slow or stopped traffic) is formally legalized. CHP guidelines recommend speeds under 10 mph faster than traffic and under 30 mph overall.

Q4 California's DUI probation period for vehicular manslaughter while intoxicated (as of 2026) is:

- A 1–2 years
- B 2–3 years
- C 3–5 years

✓ **Correct Answer: C) 3–5 years**

AB 1087 (effective January 1, 2026) increased probation for vehicular manslaughter while intoxicated from 2 years to 3–5 years, aligning it with standard DUI probation terms.

Q5 California requires Ignition Interlock Devices (IID) for:

- A Only repeat DUI offenders
- B Certain DUI offenders as part of the statewide IID pilot program (extended through 2033 by AB 366)
- C All first-time offenders

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Certain DUI offenders as part of the statewide IID pilot program (extended through 2033 by AB 366)**

California's Ignition Interlock Device program (extended through January 2033 by AB 366) requires certain DUI offenders to install an IID as a condition of license reinstatement. The IID requires a passing breath test before the car will start.

**CHAPT
ER 2**

Road Signs

Q6 What shape is a STOP sign?

- A Pentagon
- B Circle
- C Octagon

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Give right of way — slow and stop only if necessary**

The octagon is used exclusively for STOP signs in the U.S., making them recognizable even when obscured. A full stop is required every time, regardless of conditions.

Q7 A YIELD sign requires you to:

- A Stop completely
- B Give right of way — slow and stop only if necessary
- C Proceed without slowing

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Entry to this road or lane is prohibited — you are going the wrong way**

Yield means slow down and give the right of way. Stop only if traffic or pedestrians require it. The key is: give way, do not force others to adjust for you.

Q8 A 'Do Not Enter' sign means:

- A Road under construction
- B Entry to this road or lane is prohibited — you are going the wrong way
- C Parking not allowed

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Passing from your lane is not permitted**

Do Not Enter signs are placed at one-way road exits and highway off-ramp ends. If you see this sign, you must not enter the road — you would be going against traffic.

Q9 A solid yellow center line on your side means:

- A You may pass when clear
- B Passing from your lane is not permitted
- C Speed limit is 55 mph

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Distances and directions to destinations**

A solid yellow line on your side of the road prohibits passing from your lane. This is a legal requirement, not just a suggestion.

Q10 Green highway signs indicate:

- A Warnings
- B Distances and directions to destinations
- C Service locations

✓ **Correct Answer: C) Construction and work zones**

Green signs provide navigation: route numbers, city names, distances, and exit information. They help you plan your lane position well in advance of exits and turns.

CHAPTER 3**Rules of the Road****Q11 At a 4-way stop, if you arrive first, you:**

- A Must yield to cross traffic
- B Have the right of way and may proceed when safe
- C Must wait 3 seconds

✓ **Correct Answer: B) The vehicle on the right**

First to arrive, first to go. If you clearly arrived before all other vehicles and stopped, you have the right of way. Proceed when safe.

Q1 Two vehicles arrive at a 4-way stop at the same time. Who goes first?

2

- A The vehicle going straight
- B The vehicle on the right
- C The vehicle on the left

✓ **Correct Answer: B) At all crosswalks — marked and unmarked**

Simultaneous arrival: yield to the vehicle on your right. This rule applies in all 50 states.

Q1 You must always yield to pedestrians:

3

- A Only if the light is red
- B At all crosswalks — marked and unmarked
- C Only in school zones

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Yield to all oncoming vehicles and pedestrians**

Pedestrian safety is the highest priority at all times. Yield at all crosswalks. An unmarked crosswalk exists at every intersection corner.

Q1 When turning left at a green light (no arrow), you must:

4

- A Turn without yielding
- B Yield to all oncoming vehicles and pedestrians
- C Proceed immediately — you have the right of way

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Signal, check mirrors, check blind spot by looking over your shoulder, then change lanes when safe**

A solid green light permits a left turn but it is unprotected. You must yield to all oncoming traffic and pedestrians before turning.

Q1 Before changing lanes on a highway, you should:

5

- A Signal and move immediately

- B Signal, check mirrors, check blind spot by looking over your shoulder, then change lanes when safe
- C Just check mirrors

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Pass on the left side except where specifically permitted to pass right**

Lane changes require a full sequence: signal, check both mirrors, check blind spot (look over your shoulder), then move smoothly when there is a clear gap.

Q1 6 When passing another vehicle, you must:

- A Pass on either side
- B Pass on the left side except where specifically permitted to pass right
- C Pass from any lane

✓ **Correct Answer: B) You can see the vehicle's full front in your rearview mirror**

In the U.S., you must pass on the left except in specific circumstances: the vehicle ahead is turning left, you are on a one-way road, or in a multi-lane road where passing on the right is safe.

CHAPT ER 4

Safety & Emergencies

Q1 7 Headlights are required when:

- A Only at night
- B At night AND whenever visibility is reduced — rain, fog, dust, or dawn/dusk
- C Only in rain

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Low beams or dedicated fog lights**

Headlights serve two purposes: to see and to be seen. Turn them on anytime visibility is poor. Many states require headlights whenever windshield wipers are in use.

Q1 8 In fog, use:

- A High beams
- B Low beams or dedicated fog lights
- C No lights — they reflect back

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Get all occupants out immediately and move away from the tracks — at 45 degrees toward the oncoming train's direction if one is approaching**

High beams reflect off fog particles and reduce visibility. Low beams and fog lights project light at a lower angle, improving your ability to see the road without creating glare.

**Q1
9**

If your vehicle stalls on railroad tracks, your first action is:

- A Try to restart the engine
- B Get all occupants out immediately and move away from the tracks — at 45 degrees toward the oncoming train's direction if one is approaching
- C Call 911 while remaining inside

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Downshift to a lower gear to use engine braking and reduce reliance on friction brakes**

Never stay in a vehicle stalled on tracks. Exit immediately. Move at a 45-degree angle toward the approaching train if one is coming — this minimizes risk from debris in a collision.

**Q2
0**

If your brakes feel 'soft' or fade on a long downhill, you should:

- A Pump the brakes repeatedly
- B Downshift to a lower gear to use engine braking and reduce reliance on friction brakes
- C Pull off the road immediately

✓ **Correct Answer: B) Make all inputs — steering, accelerating, braking — slowly and gently; sudden movements cause skids**

Continuous braking on long downgrades causes brake fade from heat buildup. Downshifting uses engine compression to slow the vehicle and reduces brake wear and heat.

**CHAPT
ER 5**

California Laws, DUI & Penalties

**Q2
1**

What does a flashing red light mean?

- A Yield — slow down
- B Stop completely and treat it as a stop sign
- C Caution — light is broken

✓ **Correct Answer: B) The car on the right**

Flashing red = STOP sign. Come to a complete stop, yield to all traffic, and proceed only when safe.

**Q2
2**

Who has the right of way when two cars arrive at a 4-way stop simultaneously?

- A The car going straight
- B The car on the right
- C The car on the left

✓ **Correct Answer: C) 0.08%**

At simultaneous arrival, the driver on the right has the right of way.

**Q2
3**

The BAC limit for drivers 21+ in California is:

- A 0.04%
- B 0.06%
- C 0.08%

✓ **Correct Answer: B) No passing from your lane**

0.08% is the per se DUI limit in all 50 states.

**Q2
4**

A solid yellow line on your side of the road means:

- A You may pass when safe
- B No passing from your lane
- C Speed limit change

✓ **Correct Answer: B) 100 feet**

Solid yellow on your side = no passing permitted from your lane.

**Q2
5**

You must signal a turn at least how far in advance?

- A 25 feet
- B 100 feet
- C 500 feet

✓ **Correct Answer: C) 1,000 feet**

100 feet minimum; 300 feet on high-speed roads.

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